Philadelphia Poems

By Lynn Hoffman

This poetry compilation is best performed with very strong character development. Consider 4 different speakers with unique character qualities, speech patterns and mannerisms to bring the stories of these 4 Philadelphia citizens to life.

INTRODUCTION

Lynn Hoffman's latest book Philadelphia Poems could have been titled "Philadelphia Stories" as it explores his city in a series of fast paced scenes and moments. He serves up a colorful cast of characters, some more savory than others. There's the weight lifter who embraces Hawaiian shirts; the self-proclaimed prophet; the crazy, or not so crazy, poet and the aging man with a less than stellar childhood. Add in the gritty language of the neighborhood and these moments come dramatically to life. Philadelphia Poems by Lynn Hoffman.

bennny d goes hawaiian 3:19

benny d is sitting outside gleaner's coffee shop on

ninth

street.

he's got a book of poems and a braid of fresh

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mozzarella.

the mozz cost seven bucks at talluto's, the book was a

deuce at gilmore's

it's a big book, but benny's stuck on one line

e consarlo dell'umano stato

'and console him for being human'

the poet's saying what parents should do for kids

and benny d's thinking that he could use

a cupla spoonfuls of consolation right now

to go with the thick smoky coffee he's drinking

and this certain memory that makes his world

sad and yellow and jaundiced in the eye.

then this guy stops beside his table.

the guy's not too steady on his feet,

swaying in wind that blows off his personal ice cap

he points at benny d and make a prophecy.

"you" he says "should wear hawaiian shirts, that way you

won't look freaky."

now benny d lifts weights, reads a lot of poetry

and sometimes he wears big floppy hats to keep the

sun
from bouncing off his bald head and blinding the
pigeons who-he fears-might hurt themselves
by flying blind in a dangerous neighborhood.
but he ain't freaky, no way
at least not how we measure things down
here, south of washington ave.

but benny's a reasonable man and so
as the prophet is blown uptown, benny is moved.
he feels the weight of his being human
he wants it lifted, he wants to be consoled
for the freakishness of this whole human business.
so he leaves his coffee, walks home and puts on
the one hawaiian shirt he owns: yellow with faded red
orchids and suddenly things don't feel so bad.

the next morning, benny's at the thrift shop and he's
got three more hawaiian shirts. he practices standing
next to the fruit stands on ninth street,
sometimes with the grapes, sometimes with papayas.

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benny's not a man you laugh at so people don't
but they smile and three or four times an hour
someone compliments his shirt-
the green one with the parrot or the pale blue
shirt with the surfers or even the one that's all
    pineapples.
usually it's a woman doing the complimenting
and if you ask benny d these days how it's going
he's likely to tell you that it's great, just freakin'
great.

Crazy Man

crazy man's walking down walnut street
talking to himself, no, not just talking
pointing hands, cutting slices of invisible provolone,
pounding an airy lectern,
slapping fist to chest and raising his chin to heaven
    offering up his
special understanding of the nature of things and
    urging heaven to agree

and give him oh give him lordy man, a sign, a nod
a yesyes even if only he can hear
the big uh-huh. then he will close the deal
with the great understanding and the cosmic heart and
    mind and wallet
will embrace him and by the time he reaches
    Rittenhouse square he will be
affirmed by the firm, understood by those with
    standing, not withstanding
that no one but him heard a thing on walnut street that
    day.

he could be rabid-bat, gnat-flicking, pinky-sticking
    suitcase nuts.
he could be living inside a bread bag where
there's nothing but him and six invisible pets
and chandeliers made out of fine-wrought wire-taut
    thought.
or
he could be just another guy with a phone
in his skull who's walking while he's talking to a woman

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who won't quite do just yet just now just what
or
he could be a poet trying to get a ruling
that it's really all one big pretzel
no matter how you salt it.
and ain't it a shame about the rest of us
walking the other way, looking at
the crazy man lover poet and not knowing
which one he is
or which one we'll be
when we poke our very own hands in the air
and drum our breasts
on the other, rather side of the square.

Louie Scungil' Saves the World

the ladies with the perfect hair ankle their
way off the sidewalk to avoid running into louie scungil'.
gay tom's dogs scoot sideways barking
and the bartender with the pink tattooed scalp
lowers her head and raises her step count

passing louie scungil' who is drunk enough
by seven p.m. on april first to embrace the world
and drunk enough to have just *whizzed* in the
fountain
at primo levy plaza where passyunk crosses tasker.
'i love you' louie screams 'love ya . . . love youse all'
'i am the messiah' he says 'jesus came back'.
there's almost-silence on the street,
the old guys hangin' on the corner,
they don't say nothin' because they went to school
with louie's brother and the perfect hair ladies
don't say nothin' because there's nothin' to say.
but fat joey, he's walking by, he turns to louie,
real loud: "you ain't no messiah.
i know 'cause I'm the messiah."
and one of the hair ladies, the one from Haddonfield,
ronelle, she stops and takes a step to louie
"hey louie, it's me, ronelle. i'm the messiah.
me and my son anthony too, we'll save you're a**
and I guess you know what
gay tom's dogs said and you can image up

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the corner boys all tapping their chests and
saying soft "it's me it's me" and all the waves
of cooks and saints and blowhards up and down
the avenue yelling into the smoky spring night
"I, I, yo, I am the promised one, me me."
and you can image up right now that you and me
and louie scungil' and all of them
were swept along the curb and into spring south philly
air"
blown past stoops and high into the center city night
and just like that, we were saved.
yeah, saved,

Drinking Homebrew in Eddy's Kitchen

It's a brown-ale, light-weight, herbal, kinda sugary
It goes down quick like sea-foam bubbles popping on
the beach.
Eddy's talking, telling the pictures on the wall-
The ones too rough for the parlor, too sweet for the

shoe box:
Him in his Navy whites. Eddy and Kate on their
wedding. Him on the Basketball court with two boys,
one dead now, one moved to Any-Zona.
His voice all light and white-thin as the peel of a
garlic just as dry, as likely to be blown away by a
belch
or a puff of air.
He's spinning spider threads-soft, sticky, weak and
strong. "The secret is honey." he says.
"That and some rosemary from the bush in the
back." He's talking about the beer, of course,
About what you bring from far away, what you keep
at home. There's a shot of their old house in
Kensington,
One of his Dad on a day when he was sober almost
'til dusk. Another of Eddy and Kate in front of a
cabin,
two little boys in mid-squirm on the steps.
Eddy rinses out the bottles, gets two more.
I ask about the black and white dog in the frame

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with the hearts "That's Buster." he says like I
didn't
know
and then he can't say no more.
"Ah, don't get him started on his dear old dog." Kate
says she goes on like she was a TV show.
"He's really just weepy for his lost childhood."
But I know Eddy's childhood, no honey, not much
rosemary, love mashed into nothin', ferment dried
and gone.
"To Buster!" I say.
And Eddy and me, we drink to that.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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